earliest years. It split the Cabinet right down the middle, forcing Nehru to mount a strenuous defence of his position against his critics. Despite this, the short life of the provisional parliament (1950–52) saw four high-profile resignations rock the government: those of Rehabilitation Minister K.C. Neogy, Industries Minister Syama Prasad Mookerjee, Finance Minister John Matthai[27] and Law Minister B.R. Ambedkar. Alongside other factors, all four pointed to deep misgivings over the direction and orientation of India's foreign policy as a key reason for their departure from the Cabinet, Ambedkar going as far as calling it a cause 'not merely for dissatisfaction, but for actual anxiety and even worry'.[28]

It is in this context that the Patel-Nehru tussle in 1950 over the direction of India's foreign policy unfolded.

ON 26 MARCH 1950, when Nehru wrote to Patel to complain about the critical comments that he had made to restive Congress MPs about the government's foreign policy, it was already apparent that serious doubts had begun to be expressed within the government about the intellectual foundations of Nehruvianism when it came to India's relationship with its neighbours. The trigger in this case was, of course, Pakistan – but, as the exchange bears out, the background remained the direction Indian policy had been taking when it came to China and Southeast Asia.

January and February 1950 had been particularly bloody months for Bengal. State-sponsored pogroms in East Pakistan – what had once been East Bengal – had pushed thousands upon thousands of Hindu refugees into West Bengal, causing a steady deterioration of the communal situation and heightening tensions between India and Pakistan. Disorder spread through much of the province, and the police were frequently called out, often resorting to firing to bring the situation under control. Nehru had been proposing confidence-building measures, joint commissions and joint tours to affected areas to a reluctant Liaquat Ali Khan, his Pakistani counterpart. By March, he came under intense pressure from all quarters – including his